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Flock is under fire. SF's moderate Democrats are doubling down on the cameras

The technology company has lost contracts in many blue cities, but local leaders are largely defending the SFPD's use of surveillance devices.



Supervisor Matt Dorsey said the abuses of Flock cameras are not outweighed by the technology's benefits for the San Francisco Police Department. | Morgan Ellis/The Standard

By **Dustin Gardiner** and **Omar Rashad**

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Flock Safety is in the throes of a national public-relations crisis. But San Francisco's moderate Democratic political establishment is doubling down on its support for surveillance cameras.

Flock, the vendor for the city's network of nearly 500 cameras and other policing devices, has faced increasing public backlash over concerns about privacy, mass surveillance, and unauthorized federal access, including fears that the data could aid the Trump administration's immigration crackdown.

A September 2025 Standard investigation found that San Francisco's Flock license-plate database was illegally accessed 1.6 million times by out-of-state agencies. Additionally, the San Francisco Police Department came out with its own internal audit, confirming that outside agencies had unauthorized access to local cameras.

Those anxieties and protests from progressive activists have led nearly 150 cities and local governments across the country to deactivate cameras or cancel their contracts with Flock. Cities and counties across the Bay Area — including Richmond, Half Moon Bay, Mountain View and Redwood City — have debated whether to pause or cancel contracts. The turbulence surrounding the company has been so rough that its leaders are considering a sale, Semafor reported Wednesday.



A DeFlock advocacy sticker warns drivers about an automated license-plate reader. | (Photo by Smith Collection/Gado/Getty Images)

In San Francisco, however, the effort to scale back police surveillance hasn't gained traction. Moderates, who hold a majority on the Board of Supervisors, are largely defending the SFPD's use of automated license-plate readers and speed cameras, noting that crime rates have plummeted in recent years after a pandemic-era surge in theft and fentanyl addiction frustrated voters.

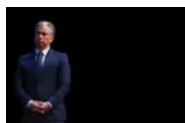
District Attorney Brooke Jenkins argues that the city's approach reflects the mood of voters who support the program because they don't want crime to rebound. Jenkins noted that, unlike in other cities debating Flock contracts, San Francisco voters approved a 2024 ballot measure that expanded the SFPD's authority to use drones and cameras.

"It's ever present in people's minds that it wasn't that long ago that they had lost confidence in us, and the city was in a much different place," Jenkins said. "San Francisco is doing well; we are coming back."

A recent poll commissioned by Grow SF, an influential moderate advocacy group, found that likely voters are broadly supportive of the SFPD using surveillance cameras. The survey found that 64% are in favor of police using cameras to target crime hubs like open-air drug markets, while 72% support police using drones and cameras to pursue suspects after a 911 call. Those questions, however, didn't gauge voters' feelings about Flock as a company.



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At City Hall, supervisors and Mayor Daniel Lurie are weighing whether the city needs additional safety guardrails to limit how data from its Flock system is stored and used. Rumblings about policy changes have cropped up in recent days.

Lurie's office declined to comment on any proposals, though the mayor has been a vocal defender of the SFPD using drones and surveillance cameras.

But even as moderate Democrats defend surveillance efforts, privacy activists are forcing them to debate the issue. That tension spilled out Wednesday night, when the San Francisco Democratic Party County Central Committee debated a pair of competing resolutions on the issue.

Protesters at the meeting criticized the local Democratic Party's ties to Flock: Two of its voting members — Trevor Chandler and Lily Ho — work on the company's public affairs

team. As recently as last week, Ho defended Flock cameras during a tense community town hall in Santa Rosa.

“You cannot be a paid advocate for a surveillance product and be a neutral arbiter of its oversight,” a San Francisco resident said at the meeting Wednesday.



Anti-Flock protesters, some of whom are associated with the DeFlock San Francisco group, raise banners during a meeting of the county Democratic Party on Wednesday. | Omar Rashad/The Standard

The county party, which is controlled by moderate Democrats, approved two resolutions supporting the SFPD’s use of license-plate readers and speed cameras. It defeated a resolution from former Supervisor Gordon Mar that called for suspending the use of Flock cameras until the SFPD can prove it’s able to cut off camera access to out-of-state and federal law enforcement agencies.

During the meeting, privacy activists, including the teenagers behind DeFlock SF, protested for about two minutes, hoisting signs equating the local Democratic Party to “big tech

puppets.”

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Mar, whose Flock resolution previously stalled in August, said he was surprised to see that two of his Democratic Party colleagues — Supervisor Matt Dorsey and DCCC Chair Nancy Tung — proposed counter-resolutions.

Moderates on the DCCC used a similar maneuver in August, when they put a competing resolution on the agenda during a debate over Proposition 40, also known as the Billionaires Tax. The local party ended up bucking the statewide Democratic Party by opposing the proposed tax on California’s ultra-wealthy and instead endorsed a competing resolution advocating for a national wealth tax.

“In both instances,” Mar told The Standard, “a corporate-funded majority is acting as a shield for tech interests and wealthy campaign backers over core democratic values like healthcare equity, civil liberties, and sanctuary protections.”



Former Supervisor Gordon Mar at Wednesday's meeting. | Omar Rashad/The Standard

Flock critics also seized on the SFPD's audit, released in June, which revealed that federal and out-of-state agencies had "improperly" accessed data from cameras hundreds of times in the previous year. Abuses have also come from within the department: In February, officials revealed that an SFPD officer used the cameras to search for his wife's stolen car, in violation of department rules.

The Democratic Party spent most of its meeting Wednesday debating Flock cameras. Tung, a county prosecutor, acknowledged instances of misuse by law enforcement but credited the SFPD for self-reporting the unauthorized access to the cameras.

Dorsey said the SFPD's response to such episodes shows that the department has safeguards to intervene when data from Flock's cameras is misused.

Dorsey, who has sparred with anti-Flock activists on social media in recent days, said his intent is to defend police using the technology, not necessarily to defend Flock as a company.

He noted that car break-ins have continued to drop, by 44% last year, since the city deployed hundreds of cameras in 2024.

“I have seen the far-left fringe do a lot of damage to this city,” said Dorsey, who previously worked as a spokesperson for the SFPD. “The knee-jerk reaction is always to deprive law enforcement agencies of tools that work.”

More about the author



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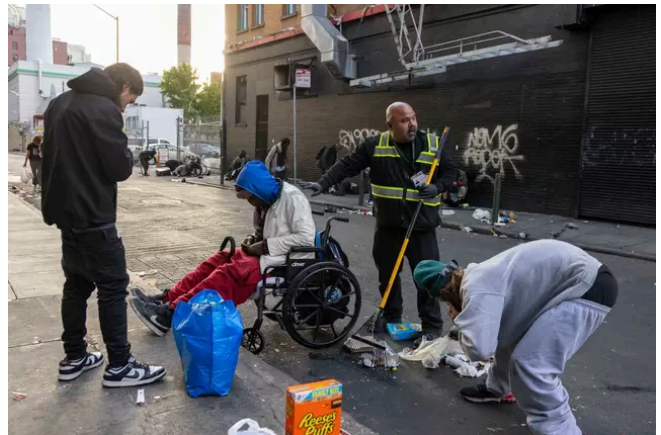
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